

YASIR IQBAL



BHARAT TIWARY

CLASS ACTS (clockwise from left) File photo of a performance at the Ravi Shankar Centre in Delhi; Pandit Ravi Shankar at a classical music event in Delhi, 2009; tabla player Bickram Ghosh; and sitarist Shubhendra Rao

sometimes refers to the Centre, or RIMPA (the Ravi Shankar Institute for Music and Performing Arts), as "our baby", a space she had helped build with her husband, the sitar maestro Pandit Ravi Shankar. "The Centre was always a place where Guruji's students could come, stay and learn from him. He wanted each student to be a complete artist, so there were halls for them to perform. Musicians like Herbie Hancock and Ravi Coltrane have given master classes here."

Starting on April 7, the 102nd birth anniversary of the Hindustani classical music legend, the three-day Ravi Shankar International Festival of Arts 2022 includes in its line-up some of Shankar's celebrated students—Vishwa Mohan Bhatt (Mohan veena), Bickram Ghosh (tabla), Shubhendra Rao (sitar)—but it also features an Odissi recital by Arushi Mudgal and a performance of folk music by Malini Awasthi. Simran Mangharam, a RIMPA trustee, explains, "The idea was always for this space to be a hub of creativity. All performing arts are promoted here. We weren't ever restricted to only classical music."

Bickram Ghosh, a disciple of Ravi Shankar, says he must have played close to 750 concerts with his guru. For him, "the Centre is the seat of the Ravi Shankar legacy in India, and anything that happens there is very important." Making the case that next week's festival is only a sign of what we can grow to expect in coming months, Ghosh speaks of the Centre's post-Covid future somewhat excitedly. He says, "For artists who have not performed in two years, it is encouraging to see auditoriums filling up."

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Shubhendra Rao echoes Ghosh's sentiment when he says that India's arts and entertainment industry was one of the worst hit during the pandemic. "We don't have any union. We don't have any fallback support system. Many, many, artists who have a hand-to-mouth existence were severely affected."

In May 2020, Rao, together with his wife, cellist Saskia Rao-de Haas, had organised 'Music for Hope', a marathon eight-hour concert, in an effort to raise funds for his beleaguered fellow musicians. Today, as he prepares to take the stage in Delhi again, the sitarist sees a silver lining. He says he is doing what he can to ensure that the Ravi Shankar festival gets broadcasted to a wider audience: "Someone from Jamaica may now be able to see you perform in Kolhapur. The reach has become bigger for concerts." ■

–Shreevatsa Nevatia

A MUSICAL JOURNEY Ayaan (left) and Amaan Ali Bangash



SUVODAS

appearance with a spoken word act on the track 'Together We Can'. "We didn't work towards any particular genre," explains Amaan. "It just felt important to let it all flow. Then it ended up being this experimental, eclectic album, which has something for everyone." The duo marvels at how easy it was to get people on board. "No one really asked questions like who else is on the album, what the line-up is like. No one charged any money. This was recorded when Omicron was settling in, times were uncertain and things had to be done remotely. Yet, everyone did their bit and we managed to pull it off," says Amaan.

The Bangash brothers have been on a musical journey all their lives, and this EP, according to them, was a monumental and profound step in that journey. When asked about what advice they would impart to children who want to pursue music, Ayaan says, "There is uncertainty in any creative field, so it is important to complete your education, to at least have a degree to fall back on." Amaan, on the other hand, follows the formula of *riyaaz* and *mijaaz*—practice and temperament, where the latter is all about having a positive attitude, being kind to others and, above all, being humble. ■

–Vijayeta Basu